# Northwind Labs
# Employee Handbook

Version 4.2, effective 1 September 2026

Owned by People Operations. Questions go to people@northwindlabs.example or the #ask-people channel.

This handbook applies to all permanent employees of Northwind Labs Ltd in the United Kingdom. Contractors should refer to their own agreements. Where this handbook and your contract disagree, your contract wins.

# 1. About Northwind Labs

Northwind Labs builds forecasting software for regional grocery and convenience chains. The company was founded in Leeds in 2019 by Hana Okafor and Dev Malhotra, and now employs around 140 people across three teams: Product, Data Science and Customer Success.

Our head office is on the fourth floor of Mill Yard, 22 Wharf Street, Leeds. We also keep a small hot-desking space in Manchester for the Customer Success team, available Monday to Friday from 08:00 to 19:00.

Our three working principles are: write things down, make small bets, and leave the campsite cleaner than you found it. You will hear them a lot.

# 2. Working hours and hybrid working

## 2.1 Core hours

A full-time week is 37.5 hours. You can choose when you start and finish, but everyone is expected to be available during core hours, 10:00 to 16:00 UK time, Monday to Friday. Meetings should not be booked outside core hours unless everyone invited has agreed.

## 2.2 Office days

We work hybrid. Everyone within 40 miles of an office is expected in on our two anchor days, Tuesday and Thursday. The rest of the week is up to you and your team. People who live further away agree an office pattern with their manager, usually one week in every month.

## 2.3 Working from abroad

You may work from another country for up to 20 working days in a calendar year. You must get written approval from your manager and People Operations at least 15 working days before you travel, because some countries create tax or immigration obligations for the company. Working from abroad is not allowed during your first three months.

# 3. Annual leave

### 3.1 Your entitlement

New starters get **25 days of annual leave** a year, plus UK bank holidays. Your entitlement goes up by one day for each full year of service, up to a maximum of 30 days. If you start or leave part way through the leave year, your entitlement is pro-rated to the nearest half day.

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December.

### 3.2 Company closure

The company closes from 24 December to 1 January inclusive. The three working days in that period that are not bank holidays are given as extra company days and are **not** taken from your annual leave.

### 3.3 Carrying leave over

You can carry up to **5 days** of unused leave into the next leave year. Carried-over days must be used by 31 March, or they are lost. Leave above 5 days cannot be carried over or paid out, except when you leave the company (see section 11).

### 3.4 Booking leave

Book leave in Harbour, our HR portal, giving at least **two weeks' notice** for anything longer than two days. Shorter absences need at least two working days' notice. Your manager approves or declines within five working days. Teams should not have more than a third of their members on leave at the same time during the last two weeks of a quarter.

### 3.5 Buying extra leave

Once a year, in November, you can buy up to 5 extra days of leave for the following year through salary sacrifice. The cost is spread evenly over the twelve months.

# 4. Sickness absence

If you are ill, tell your manager by 10:00 on your first day of absence, by message or phone. Do not just post in a team channel.

You can self-certify for up to **7 calendar days**. After that, we need a fit note from a doctor. Self-certified days are recorded in Harbour by your manager.

| Length of service | Company sick pay at full salary |
|---|---|

| | |
|---|---|
| Less than 1 year | 10 working days in any rolling 12 months |
| 1 year or more | 20 working days in any rolling 12 months |

After company sick pay runs out, you receive Statutory Sick Pay if you are eligible.

## 5. Family leave

After one year of service, a primary carer (including adopters and surrogate parents) receives **26 weeks at full pay**, followed by statutory pay. A secondary carer receives **4 weeks at full pay**, which can be taken in up to two blocks within the first year. Before one year of service, statutory family pay applies.

Everyone can take up to 5 days of paid dependants' leave a year for emergencies involving someone who depends on them.

# 6. Expenses and travel

## 6.1 Making a claim

Claim expenses in Harbour within **30 days** of spending the money. Attach a receipt for anything over £10. Claims approved by the 20th of the month are paid with that month's salary; later claims are paid the following month.

## 6.2 Approval for trips

Any trip expected to cost more than **£1,500 in total** needs approval from the budget holder **and** sign-off from Finance before anything is booked. Trips under £1,500 only need the budget holder's approval. Book through TravelDesk wherever possible so costs land on the right budget.

## 6.3 Getting there

- **Flights:** economy for flights under 6 hours; premium economy for flights of 6 hours or more. Business class is never covered.
- **Rail:** standard class, except for journeys longer than 3 hours, where first class is allowed if it costs no more than 30% above the standard fare.
- **Driving your own car:** 45p a mile for the first 10,000 business miles in a tax year, then 25p a mile.
- **Taxis:** only when there is no reasonable public transport, or between 22:00 and 06:00.

## 6.4 Hotels

Hotel rates are capped per night, including breakfast and taxes:

| Location | Maximum per night |
|---|---|
| London | £180 |
| Rest of the UK | £140 |
| European Union | €170 |
| Rest of the world | Agreed with Finance before booking |

## 6.5 Meals

On days when you travel overnight for work, you can claim up to **£45 a day** for meals. Alcohol is not covered by the daily allowance.

Client entertainment is covered up to **£75 a head**, including drinks, for a client dinner. The most senior Northwind person present pays and claims. Entertainment over this limit needs written approval from a director in advance.

## 7. Equipment

On your first day you choose a laptop: a 14-inch MacBook Pro or a Lenovo ThinkPad X1 Carbon. Laptops are replaced every three years, or sooner if they fail.

You also get a **£400 home-office budget** to spend on a desk, chair, monitor or similar in your first three months. The budget renews every three years. Items bought with it stay with you if you leave.

Report lost or stolen equipment to the IT team at it@northwindlabs.example within 24 hours.

## 8. Learning and development

Everyone has a **£1,000 learning budget** each calendar year and **3 learning days** to use for courses, conferences or study. Unused budget does not roll over. Ask your manager before booking anything over £300, so we can check whether a team licence or group booking would work better.

Every quarter you have a growth conversation with your manager, separate from your weekly one-to-ones, to review progress against your development plan.

## 9. Information security

- Store all work passwords in 1Password. Do not reuse passwords between services.
- Multi-factor authentication is required on every company account that supports it.
- Your laptop must lock after **5 minutes** of inactivity, and full-disk encryption must stay on.
- Customer data must never be copied to personal devices or personal cloud storage.
- Report a suspected security incident to security@northwindlabs.example within **1 hour** of noticing it, even if you are not sure. You will never be in trouble for reporting something that turns out to be harmless.

## 10. Pay and benefits

Salaries are paid on the last working day of each month. Salary reviews happen once a year, in April.

- **Pension:** we match your contributions up to **6% of salary**.
- **Private health insurance** after your probation period, including cover for a partner or children at no extra cost.
- **Cycle to Work** scheme, up to £2,500.
- A confidential **Employee Assistance Programme**, available 24 hours a day.

Probation lasts 3 months. Your manager may extend it once, by up to another 3 months.

## 11. Leaving Northwind Labs

| Role | Notice period |
|---|---|
| Under 2 years of service | 1 month |
| 2 years or more | 2 months |
| Leads and directors | 3 months |

Unused annual leave for the current year is paid out in your final salary. Return your laptop and access cards on your last day; IT will send a prepaid box if you work remotely.